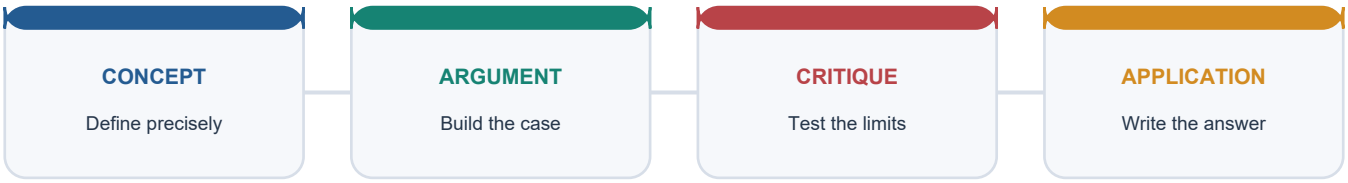
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Imperial Cholas: State, Society, Economy & Maritime Power - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Imperial Cholas: State, Society, Economy & Maritime Power - Solved Practice Workbook 3

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 3

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE 16

Solved topic-specific MCQs 16

Imperial Cholas: State, Society, Economy & Maritime Power - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 Original Hard MCQs - Full Option-Level Explanations

MCQ 01

Question: Which combination best explains why the Imperial Cholas are treated as a major early-medieval regional empire?

A. Agrarian surplus, conquest, local institutions, temple power and selective maritime reach B. Only local democracy without kingship C. Only maritime trade without agrarian foundations D. Purely temple-centred art without military activity

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q01-A]** Correct: this combination preserves every pillar the package actually teaches - agrarian surplus, conquest, local institutions, temple power and selective maritime reach - without reducing the Cholas to any single dimension.
- **[Q01-B]** Wrong: Uttaramerur's committee system operated inside strong Chola kingship, conquest and survey; it never replaced or excluded royal authority.
- **[Q01-C]** Wrong: maritime trade depended on the inland Kaveri agrarian base for provisioning, labour and fiscal backing; it was not a self-sufficient commercial state.
- **[Q01-D]** Wrong: temples were major institutions, but Chola power also rested on conquest, survey, taxation and military campaigning, not on art alone.

Examiner trap: Reducing a composite early-medieval empire to just one of its pillars (democracy, trade or art).

MCQ 02

Question: Vijayalaya's historical significance lies primarily in:

A. launching the 1025 raid on Srivijaya B. capturing Tanjavur and establishing the lower Kaveri foothold of the imperial line C. building Airavatesvara temple D. expelling the Cholas from Sri Lanka

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q02-A]** Wrong: the 1025 raid belongs to Rajendra I, roughly two centuries after Vijayalaya's founding capture.
- **[Q02-B]** Correct: Vijayalaya's capture of Tanjavur from the Muttaraiyar chiefs created the territorial and dynastic foothold from which the imperial line grew.
- **[Q02-C]** Wrong: Airavatesvara at Darasuram is a later Chola monument, associated with Rajaraja II, not the 9th-century founder.
- **[Q02-D]** Wrong: it was Vijayabahu I of Sri Lanka, not a Chola ruler, who expelled the Cholas from the island in 1070.

Examiner trap: Attaching a founder's name to events from much later reigns, collapsing three centuries of chronology into one figure.

MCQ 03

Question: The battle of Takkolam is most important because it:

A. created the Chudamani Vihara B. ended Tamil-Sanskrit bilingualism C. marked a major Chola setback before later recovery D. destroyed Srivijaya

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q03-A]** Wrong: the Chudamani Vihara grant is a Nagapattinam Buddhist-patronage episode under Rajaraja I, unconnected to the Rashtrakuta battle.
- **[Q03-B]** Wrong: Tanjavur's capture belongs to the founding phase under Vijayalaya, roughly a century before Takkolam.
- **[Q03-C]** Correct: the Rashtrakuta victory at Takkolam in 949 CE checked Parantaka I's expansion and is the key 10th-century reversal before Rajaraja I's later recovery.
- **[Q03-D]** Wrong: Srivijaya was raided by Rajendra I in 1025, a maritime campaign with no connection to the Deccan land battle of Takkolam.

Examiner trap: Confusing a Deccan land-battle setback with a much later overseas maritime campaign.

MCQ 04

Question: Which ruler is most closely associated with Brihadisvara at Thanjavur and the great imperial survey?

A. Aditya I B. Kulottunga II C. Vijayalaya D. Rajaraja I

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q04-A]** Wrong: Aditya I is associated with the Pallava-eclipse and Tondaimandalam gain, not Brihadisvara or the survey.
- **[Q04-B]** Wrong: Kulottunga II is a much later ruler unconnected with Brihadisvara's original construction or Rajaraja's survey.
- **[Q04-C]** Wrong: Vijayalaya is the founder figure of Tanjavur, over a century before Brihadisvara or the imperial survey.
- **[Q04-D]** Correct: Rajaraja I anchors both the monumental Brihadisvara temple and the survey-based articulation of imperial revenue and control.

Examiner trap: Attaching the temple/survey combination to a founder or later ruler instead of the reign that actually produced both.

MCQ 05

Question: In Chola political geography, the safest description of the Maldives is:

A. campaign or maritime-reach zone, not core territory B. permanent province equivalent to the Kaveri delta C. brahmadeya heartland D. hereditary Chola homeland

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q05-A]** Correct: evidence supports Chola capture claims for the Maldives, but not treatment of it as a stable core province like the Kaveri delta.
- **[Q05-B]** Wrong: no evidence treats the Maldives as administratively equivalent to the Kaveri delta core.
- **[Q05-C]** Wrong: the Maldives is not part of the brahmadeya heartland, which is a Tamil-mainland agrarian-institutional category.
- **[Q05-D]** Wrong: the Maldives was never a hereditary Chola homeland; the homeland is the lower Kaveri delta around Tanjavur.

Examiner trap: Upgrading a campaign or maritime-reach zone into a stable, mainland-equivalent province.

MCQ 06

Question: Which division became especially important in Chola revenue administration after Rajaraja I?

A. ahara B. valanadu C. visaya D. janapada

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q06-A]** Wrong: ahara is not the Chola-era term used in this package's administrative ladder; it belongs to a different regional/period vocabulary.
- **[Q06-B]** Correct: valanadu is a high-yield Chola revenue-administrative division, especially prominent after Rajaraja I in the later 10th and 11th centuries.
- **[Q06-C]** Wrong: visaya is an earlier/other-dynasty administrative term, not the Chola-specific division tested here.
- **[Q06-D]** Wrong: janapada is an ancient pre-Mauryan territorial-political unit, unrelated to Chola-era revenue reorganisation.

Examiner trap: Substituting an earlier or unrelated-period administrative term for the specific Chola-era division.

MCQ 07

Question: The ur in Chola inscriptions refers primarily to:

A. a bronze-casting guild B. the royal court C. the corporate body of a non-brahmadeya village D. a Southeast Asian trade mission

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q07-A]** Wrong: bronze-casting guilds are craft-artisan bodies, unrelated to ur, which is a village assembly.
- **[Q07-B]** Wrong: the royal court is the king's central establishment, not a local village-level institution like ur.
- **[Q07-C]** Correct: ur is the corporate body of a non-brahmadeya village, distinct from the Brahmana sabha and the merchant nagaram.
- **[Q07-D]** Wrong: Southeast Asian trade missions belong to the maritime-diplomatic theme, not to the local-institution vocabulary of ur.

Examiner trap: Confusing the specific local-institution term with an unrelated craft, court or overseas-diplomatic category.

MCQ 08

Question: Which statement best captures the historical importance of the sabha?

A. It was a title used only for kings. B. It was a Buddhist monastery network. C. It was identical to nagaram. D. It was the Brahmana assembly of a brahmadeya settlement with strong committee and fiscal functions.

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q08-A]** Wrong: sabha was not a royal-only title; it denoted a specific corporate assembly, not kingship.
- **[Q08-B]** Wrong: sabha is a Tamil Brahmadeya institution, not a Buddhist monastery network.
- **[Q08-C]** Wrong: sabha and nagaram are institutionally distinct - one Brahmana, one merchant/urban - so they cannot be treated as identical.
- **[Q08-D]** Correct: sabha or mahasabha was the Brahmana assembly of a brahmadeya settlement, with strong committee and fiscal functions as at Uttaramerur.

Examiner trap: Collapsing a precise institutional term into an unrelated category or into a different local institution.

MCQ 09

Question: The most accurate statement about Uttaramerur is that it:

A. offers detailed procedural evidence for committee selection in a Brahmadeya sabha B. established universal suffrage in all Chola villages C. records only temple architecture D. proves that all social groups participated equally

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q09-A]** Correct: Uttaramerur offers detailed procedural evidence - the kudavolai draw, committee names, age rules and disqualifications - for committee selection in a Brahmadeya sabha.
- **[Q09-B]** Wrong: eligibility for the draw was restricted by land, age, scriptural competence and moral standing, so it did not establish universal suffrage.
- **[Q09-C]** Wrong: Uttaramerur is an administrative-governance inscription, not primarily an architectural record.
- **[Q09-D]** Wrong: the qualifications and disqualifications listed show unequal, not equal, participation across social groups.

Examiner trap: Turning a bounded, procedurally sophisticated elite-governance inscription into evidence for universal or equal participation.

MCQ 10

Question: Which named committee at Uttaramerur is associated with tank management?

A. Samvatsara Variyam B. Eri Variyam C. Thotta Variyam D. Pon Variyam

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q10-A]** Wrong: Samvatsara Variyam is the annual/general-affairs committee, not the tank-management body.
- **[Q10-B]** Correct: Eri means tank, making Eri Variyam the specific Uttaramerur committee responsible for irrigation-tank management.
- **[Q10-C]** Wrong: Thotta Variyam relates to garden/orchard land, not tank irrigation specifically.
- **[Q10-D]** Wrong: Pon Variyam is the gold/treasury-related committee, unconnected to irrigation management.

Examiner trap: Confusing the several named Uttaramerur committees, which each had a distinct specific remit.

MCQ 11

Question: Which statement about Chola land surveys is most accurate?

A. They ended temple endowments. B. They eliminated local institutions entirely. C. They reveal stronger fiscal articulation while still depending on local implementation. D. They belong only to Sangam times.

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q11-A]** Wrong: temple endowments continued after Rajaraja I's survey; the survey recorded rather than ended them.
- **[Q11-B]** Wrong: local institutions such as ur, sabha and nagaram continued to function and execute assessment after the survey.
- **[Q11-C]** Correct: survey evidence reveals stronger fiscal articulation by the state, while collection and local management still moved through village and nadu-level bodies.
- **[Q11-D]** Wrong: knowledge of the survey itself is drawn from inscriptions, so it does not show a decline in inscriptional practice.

Examiner trap: Reading a centralising fiscal measure as either total local elimination or total central takeover.

MCQ 12

Question: The term brahmadeya most directly refers to:

A. an overseas commercial pact B. a military regiment C. a sculptural style D. a Brahmana land-grant settlement

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q12-A]** Wrong: brahmadeya is a land-grant category, not an overseas commercial arrangement such as a guild pact.
- **[Q12-B]** Wrong: brahmadeya refers to a land settlement, not a military unit.
- **[Q12-C]** Wrong: brahmadeya is an institutional-agrarian term, not an art-historical style category.
- **[Q12-D]** Correct: brahmadeya denotes a Brahmana land-grant settlement, central to Chola agrarian, social and institutional history and often sabha-centred.

Examiner trap: Substituting an unrelated commercial, military or stylistic category for the precise land-grant term.

MCQ 13

Question: Which statement best describes the place of vellalas in Chola society?

A. They were major cultivators and powerful local landholders. B. They were foreign merchants from Southeast Asia. C. They had no connection to landholding. D. They were marginal forest nomads only.

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q13-A]** Correct: vellalas were major cultivators and powerful local landholders, crucial agrarian elites despite a Shudra classification in Brahmanical theory.
- **[Q13-B]** Wrong: vellalas were a local Tamil agrarian group, not foreign merchants from Southeast Asia.
- **[Q13-C]** Wrong: vellalas held substantial landed power; they were not disconnected from landholding.
- **[Q13-D]** Wrong: vellalas were settled agrarian landholders, not marginal forest nomads.

Examiner trap: Detaching the central agrarian elite from land and status, or relocating them as a foreign or marginal group.

MCQ 14

Question: Which named royal woman is most closely linked with temple rebuilding and image patronage?

A. Nur Jahan B. Sembiyan Mahadevi C. Didda D. Prabhavati Gupta

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q14-A]** Wrong: Nur Jahan was a Mughal empress, from an entirely different dynasty, region and period.
- **[Q14-B]** Correct: Sembiyan Mahadevi, wife of Gandaraditya, is the safest and most important named example for Chola-era temple rebuilding and image patronage.
- **[Q14-C]** Wrong: Didda was a Kashmiri queen of a different dynasty and region, unconnected to Chola patronage.
- **[Q14-D]** Wrong: Prabhavati Gupta belongs to the earlier Gupta-Vakataka world, a different dynasty and period.

Examiner trap: Substituting a famous queen from an unrelated dynasty or period for the specific, named Chola patron.

MCQ 15

Question: The most secure evidence for Kundavai's public role in this package is:

A. the Mahavamsa's account of Sri Lanka B. the 1025 Srivijaya raid list C. her appearance in the Brihadisvara donor inscriptional record D. a modern novel

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q15-A]** Wrong: the Mahavamsa's Sri Lankan account is a separate source tradition and does not record Kundavai's public role.
- **[Q15-B]** Wrong: the Srivijaya raid list is Rajendra I's maritime-campaign evidence, unrelated to Kundavai's donor status.
- **[Q15-C]** Correct: the IGNCA inscriptional summary confirms Rajaraja's order to record gifts by Kundavaiyar along with royal and other donors at Brihadisvara.
- **[Q15-D]** Wrong: a modern novel is not a historical evidentiary source for this package's evidence-graded claims.

Examiner trap: Substituting an unrelated source tradition or a non-historical text for the actual inscriptional evidence.

MCQ 16

Question: Which statement best defines the Chola temple institution?

A. only a site of personal devotion B. a foreign merchant office C. only a landlord without ritual significance D. a political-economic-cultural institution combining ritual, archive, labour and redistribution

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q16-A]** Wrong: reducing the temple to personal devotion ignores its documented land, archive and labour functions.
- **[Q16-B]** Wrong: the temple was an indigenous Chola-Tamil institution, not a foreign merchant office.
- **[Q16-C]** Wrong: temples held land and had ritual significance simultaneously; they were not landlords without ritual meaning.
- **[Q16-D]** Correct: great Chola temples functioned as political-economic-cultural institutions combining ritual, archive, labour and redistribution.

Examiner trap: Reducing a multi-functional institution to a single narrow function (devotion, commerce, or landlordism alone).

MCQ 17

Question: The Great Living Chola Temples UNESCO cluster includes:

A. Thanjavur, Gangaikondacholapuram and Darasuram B. Chidambaram, Madurai and Kanchi C. Pattadakal, Badami and Aihole D. Mahabalipuram, Kanchipuram and Darasuram

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q17-A]** Correct: UNESCO's Great Living Chola Temples cluster is exactly Thanjavur (Brihadisvara), Gangaikondacholapuram and Darasuram (Airavatesvara).
- **[Q17-B]** Wrong: Chidambaram, Madurai and Kanchi are major Tamil temple towns but are not the three UNESCO-listed Chola sites.
- **[Q17-C]** Wrong: Pattadakal, Badami and Aihole are Chalukyan-dynasty sites in Karnataka, unrelated to the Chola UNESCO cluster.
- **[Q17-D]** Wrong: Mahabalipuram and Kanchipuram are Pallava-associated sites; only Darasuram belongs to the actual UNESCO Chola cluster.

Examiner trap: Substituting other famous Tamil or south Indian temple towns for the three specifically UNESCO-listed Chola monuments.

MCQ 18

Question: Which statement about Chola bronzes is correct?

A. They were detached from temple institutions. B. They were made through the lost-wax process. C. They were carved only in granite. D. They never moved in procession.

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q18-A]** Wrong: bronzes were integral to temple institutions, receiving offerings and participating in festivals, not detached from them.
- **[Q18-B]** Correct: Chola bronzes were produced through the lost-wax (cire perdue) casting process.
- **[Q18-C]** Wrong: 'carved only in granite' describes stone temple sculpture, not the cast-metal bronze tradition.
- **[Q18-D]** Wrong: bronzes were specifically processional images, carried out of the sanctum during festivals.

Examiner trap: Confusing the bronze-casting tradition with stone-carving or denying its documented ritual mobility.

MCQ 19

Question: The most balanced statement about Nataraja is that:

A. it had no theological meaning B. it was a Mughal court icon C. the Cholas brought the form to exceptional refinement, though antecedents may be earlier D. it proves total Chola political control over India

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q19-A]** Wrong: Nataraja carries a specific theological programme (damaru, flame, raised hand and foot, apasmara dwarf) rather than being meaningless.
- **[Q19-B]** Wrong: the Mughals were a much later Islamic dynasty with no connection to this Hindu Shaiva bronze tradition.
- **[Q19-C]** Correct: the Cholas brought the Nataraja form to its most celebrated refinement, while earlier Pallava-period antecedents likely exist.
- **[Q19-D]** Wrong: an artistic and theological icon cannot by itself establish political control over all of India.

Examiner trap: Either denying the icon's theological content or inflating artistic achievement into a territorial-political claim.

MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best captures language use in Chola inscriptions and court culture?

A. Tamil fully replaced Sanskrit from the beginning B. neither language appears in political texts C. Sanskrit fully excluded Tamil D. Tamil and Sanskrit functioned in a layered bilingual order

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q20-A]** Wrong: Sanskrit continued to carry eulogy and cosmopolitan prestige throughout, so Tamil did not fully replace it from the start.
- **[Q20-B]** Wrong: both languages are extensively attested in the Chola inscriptional and court record.
- **[Q20-C]** Wrong: Tamil carried documentary material from early on and increasingly more administrative function later, so Sanskrit did not fully exclude it.
- **[Q20-D]** Correct: Chola cultural politics operated through a layered bilingual order, with each language handling different functions.

Examiner trap: Claiming exclusive dominance for one language rather than recognising their functional layering.

MCQ 21

Question: Which guild name is most strongly linked with transregional long-distance trade in the Chola world?

A. Ayyavole / Ainnurruvar B. gana-sangha of the Mallas C. Kula of the Yavanas D. Licchavi gana

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q21-A]** Correct: Ayyavole / Ainnurruvar is the best-known merchant guild with a wide operating range in the Chola period.
- **[Q21-B]** Wrong: the gana-sangha of the Mallas was an early republican political body, not a merchant guild.
- **[Q21-C]** Wrong: 'Kula of the Yavanas' is not a documented Chola-era guild name in the package's evidence base.
- **[Q21-D]** Wrong: the Licchavi gana was an early north Indian republican confederacy, unconnected to Chola-era Bay of Bengal trade.

Examiner trap: Substituting early republican political bodies for the actual named Chola-era merchant guild.

MCQ 22

Question: Nagapattinam is historically important because it:

A. served only as a cavalry cantonment B. linked port activity, Buddhist patronage and Chola-Srivijaya diplomacy C. was the site of Takkolam D. was the birthplace of Mahendravarman I

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q22-A]** Wrong: reducing Nagapattinam to a cavalry cantonment ignores its documented port, Buddhist and diplomatic functions.
- **[Q22-B]** Correct: Nagapattinam connects port trade, the Chudamani Vihara Buddhist patronage, and Chola-Srivijaya diplomatic grants.
- **[Q22-C]** Wrong: Takkolam was a separate inland Deccan battle site, unrelated to the port of Nagapattinam.
- **[Q22-D]** Wrong: Mahendravarman I is a Pallava ruler with no documented birthplace connection to Nagapattinam in this package.

Examiner trap: Substituting an unrelated site or ruler-biography claim for Nagapattinam's actual multi-functional significance.

MCQ 23

Question: Which statement about the 1025 expedition is most accurate?

A. It ended all trade with Southeast Asia. B. It was led by Kulottunga I. C. It was a successful maritime strike against Srivijaya-linked targets. D. It created a permanent Chola colony in Java.

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q23-A]** Wrong: Kulottunga I's later confirmation of grants to the Chudamani Vihara shows trade and diplomacy continued after 1025, not ended.
- **[Q23-B]** Wrong: Rajendra I, not Kulottunga I, led the 1025 expedition; Kulottunga I belongs to a later reign focused on consolidation.
- **[Q23-C]** Correct: the expedition was a successful maritime strike against Srivijaya-linked targets such as Kadaram.
- **[Q23-D]** Wrong: no evidence supports a permanent Chola colony in Java following the raid.

Examiner trap: Assigning the campaign to the wrong ruler or converting a successful raid into permanent colonisation.

MCQ 24

Question: The safest interpretation of Chola maritime power is that it:

A. consisted only of peaceful trade B. eliminated the need for agrarian revenue C. proves a modern-style blue-water naval state D. combined trade, diplomacy and episodic coercive capability

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q24-A]** Wrong: the 1025 expedition demonstrates coercive capacity, so maritime power was not purely peaceful trade.
- **[Q24-B]** Wrong: maritime activity itself depended on agrarian surplus for provisioning and finance; it did not replace agrarian revenue.
- **[Q24-C]** Wrong: evidence for standing naval institutions is thin, so a modern blue-water navy claim is anachronistic.
- **[Q24-D]** Correct: Chola maritime power is best framed as trade, diplomacy and episodic coercive capability working together.

Examiner trap: Reducing maritime power to one single mode (pure trade or modern navy) instead of its actual mixed character.

MCQ 25

Question: In Sri Lanka, the area most durably integrated into the Chola realm was:

A. the northern Rajarata zone B. the whole island equally C. only the western coast D. Rohana alone

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q25-A]** Correct: northern Sri Lanka (Rajarata) was organised as a Chola province for a substantial period after Rajaraja I.
- **[Q25-B]** Wrong: control was uneven; the south remained more contested than the north, so the whole island was not equally held.
- **[Q25-C]** Wrong: the western coast is not the zone the evidence identifies as the durably integrated area.
- **[Q25-D]** Wrong: Rohana in the south was the centre of recurrent resistance, the opposite of durable Chola integration.

Examiner trap: Claiming uniform island-wide control or naming the resistant south instead of the more durably held north.

MCQ 26

Question: Which statement is correct about the Chudamani Vihara connection?

A. it belongs to Gupta north India B. Rajaraja granted Anaimangalam to the Buddhist establishment at Nagapattinam C. Rajendra I built it after conquering China D. it proves the absence of war with Srivijaya

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q26-A]** Wrong: the Chudamani Vihara episode belongs to Chola-era Tamil Nadu, not Gupta north India.
- **[Q26-B]** Correct: the Leiden plates record Rajaraja I's grant of Anaimangalam village to the Chudamani Vihara at Nagapattinam.
- **[Q26-C]** Wrong: there is no evidence of a Chola conquest of China; the vihara connection is a Nagapattinam-Srivijaya patronage grant.
- **[Q26-D]** Wrong: the grant and Rajendra I's later 1025 war with Srivijaya both occurred, showing diplomacy and conflict coexisted rather than excluding each other.

Examiner trap: Relocating the episode to the wrong dynasty/period or treating one piece of evidence as cancelling out the other.

MCQ 27

Question: Which statement best captures the state of evidence on the Chola navy?

A. Detailed ship blueprints are preserved in abundance. B. The Cholas never used sea transport. C. Maritime capacity is clear, but technical and institutional naval detail remains limited. D. The navy is better documented than local taxation.

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q27-A]** Wrong: the package explicitly states that evidence on ship types and naval institutions is thin, not abundant.
- **[Q27-B]** Wrong: the Sri Lanka campaigns and the 1025 Srivijaya expedition directly demonstrate Chola sea-transport capacity.
- **[Q27-C]** Correct: maritime capacity is well evidenced through expeditions, but technical and institutional naval detail remains comparatively limited.
- **[Q27-D]** Wrong: local taxation and agrarian administration are considerably better documented in inscriptions than naval organisation.

Examiner trap: Reversing the package's actual evidence hierarchy between agrarian administration and naval detail.

MCQ 28

Question: The historian most associated with the strongly imperial and centralized narrative of the Cholas is:

A. Noboru Karashima B. Burton Stein C. B. D. Chattopadhyaya D. K. A. Nilakanta Sastri

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q28-A]** Wrong: Karashima is known for inscription-led administrative and social nuance, not the classic centralised-imperial narrative.
- **[Q28-B]** Wrong: Stein specifically challenged strong centralisation through his segmentary-state model.
- **[Q28-C]** Wrong: Chattopadhyaya is associated with integrative/regional-state historiography, a corrective rather than the classic imperial narrative.
- **[Q28-D]** Correct: Sastri's classic narrative emphasises imperial expansion, kingship, administration, temple-building and maritime achievement.

Examiner trap: Attributing the classic centralist narrative to one of its later inscription-led or segmentary-state critics.

MCQ 29

Question: Which statement most closely reflects Burton Stein's intervention?

A. Locality and ritual sovereignty complicate any simple bureaucratic-state model. B. The Chola state had no kings at all. C. Merchant guilds alone made the empire. D. Chola history can be written only from UNESCO reports.

Answer: A.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q29-A]** Correct: Stein's segmentary-state model highlighted locality and ritual sovereignty as complications for any simple bureaucratic-state reading.
- **[Q29-B]** Wrong: Stein did not deny Chola kingship; he questioned the degree and nature of centralised bureaucratic control.
- **[Q29-C]** Wrong: Stein's argument centred on ritual sovereignty and locality institutions, not merchant guilds as the sole source of empire.
- **[Q29-D]** Wrong: this is an absurd overstatement with no basis in Stein's or any historian's actual method.

Examiner trap: Converting a qualifying historiographical intervention into an absolute or absurd denial of Chola kingship.

MCQ 30

Question: Why are Karashima and Subbarayalu important for Chola studies?

A. They rejected chronology altogether. B. They pushed close inscription-based reconstruction of offices, taxes and locality structures. C. They denied the existence of all temples. D. They worked only on Mughal India.

Answer: B.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q30-A]** Wrong: their method relies on precise chronological placement of inscriptions, not a rejection of chronology.
- **[Q30-B]** Correct: Karashima and Subbarayalu are known for close inscription-based reconstruction of offices, taxes and locality structures.
- **[Q30-C]** Wrong: this is an absurd claim with no basis; temples are central to their inscriptional evidence base.
- **[Q30-D]** Wrong: their work concerns Chola-era Tamil Nadu, not Mughal India, an entirely different period and region.

Examiner trap: Attributing an absurd or period-mismatched claim to scholars actually known for meticulous epigraphic reconstruction.

MCQ 31

Question: The best way to describe later Chola decline is:

A. complete end of Tamil political memory B. sudden disappearance after Rajendra I C. multicausal contraction shaped by succession, rivals and regional rebalancing D. immediate conversion of all temples into forts

Answer: C.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q31-A]** Wrong: Tamil political and cultural memory (temples, epigraphy, land institutions) endured well beyond the empire's contraction.
- **[Q31-B]** Wrong: decline unfolded gradually across later 11th-13th century reigns, not suddenly after Rajendra I.
- **[Q31-C]** Correct: later Chola weakening came through interacting pressures - succession strain, rival powers and regional rebalancing - not one cause.
- **[Q31-D]** Wrong: there is no evidence of temples being converted into forts; temple institutions continued their religious and social functions.

Examiner trap: Converting a gradual multicausal transformation into either a sudden collapse or an unsupported dramatic claim.

MCQ 32

Question: Which concluding statement is most historically sound?

A. Chola history proves that local assemblies abolish hierarchy. B. Chola history proves that trade alone creates empire. C. The Cholas are only relevant for art history. D. The Cholas are best understood as a source-rich early-medieval empire of uneven control, strong agrarian foundations and wide cultural legacy.

Answer: D.

Option-level explanations:

- **[Q32-A]** Wrong: local assemblies such as ur, sabha and nagaram functioned inside Chola hierarchy, not as evidence against it.
- **[Q32-B]** Wrong: trade reinforced but did not by itself create the empire; agrarian surplus and military conquest were foundational.
- **[Q32-C]** Wrong: reducing Chola relevance to art history ignores its far broader significance for polity, economy and society.
- **[Q32-D]** Correct: this conclusion preserves state power, local mediation, agrarian foundations, uneven frontiers and long cultural afterlife together.

Examiner trap: Replacing a genuinely multidimensional verdict with a single-cause or single-domain overclaim.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified and routed PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims 2020 GS-I (verified stem and event list; official key unavailable locally)

Question: Consider the following events in the history of India:

1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman-I
3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka-I
4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest time?

Answer route: Mahendravarman I belongs to the early 7th century, Gopala to the mid-8th century, Bhoja of the Pratiharas to the 9th century, and Parantaka I to the early 10th century.

Model solution: The deduced order is **2 -> 4 -> 1 -> 3**. This PYQ is relevant because the Chola event is not asked in isolation. UPSC tests whether one can place Chola power within wider early-medieval chronology.

Limitation note: Local repository material verifies the stem and event list, but the official answer-key letter was not available locally at validation time because the option text was OCR-garbled in the stored extract.

Why this earns marks: It shows chronology control and places the Cholas inside the larger post-Gupta regionalization process.

Demand decoding: This item is a four-event chronological-ordering objective question: it does not ask about the Cholas alone but requires placing Parantaka I's Chola accession correctly against Mahendravarman I's Pallava accession, Gopala's Pala founding and Bhoja's Pratihara reign.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix each ruler's century first (Mahendravarman I, early 7th; Gopala, mid-8th; Bhoja, 9th; Parantaka I, early 10th), then order 2-4-1-3 and state the local-key limitation in one line.

How to improve this answer: Add the exact regnal-century anchor for each of the four rulers so the ordering is defensible even without the official key, and note explicitly that the option lettering could not be verified locally.

PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2022 (exact wording verified locally)

Question: Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (Answer in 250 words) 15

Model answer:

The Gupta and Chola periods belong to different regional and chronological worlds, yet both profoundly shaped Indian heritage and culture.

First, the Gupta contribution lay in classical synthesis. In north India, the period saw important developments in sculpture, temple beginnings, Sanskrit court culture and the consolidation of Puranic Hindu traditions. Gupta coinage, inscriptions and art created a durable idiom of kingship and sacred representation.

Second, the Chola contribution was especially strong in the south through mature Dravida architecture, temple-centered institutional life and bronze iconography. Brihadisvara at Thanjavur, Gangaikondacholapuram and Airavatesvara at Darasuram represent monumental temple achievement, while Chola bronzes - especially Nataraja - embody high metal craftsmanship and theological imagination.

Third, both periods shaped intangible heritage. Gupta-era Sanskritic learning and Chola-era Tamil-Sanskrit bilingual culture, bhakti institutionalization and sacred geographies entered long civilizational memory.

However, the contributions differed in texture. Gupta heritage is often associated with classical north Indian cultural synthesis; Chola heritage is marked by temple institutions, agrarian endowments, maritime links and durable regional-cultural power.

Verdict: Together they show that Indian heritage evolved through multiple classical centres, not a single civilizational line.

Why this earns marks: It compares rather than listing randomly, names monuments, distinguishes regions and ends with a civilizational synthesis.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires naming concrete Gupta and Chola contributions in turn, not a generic "both were golden ages" answer, and closing with a comparative civilizational verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with a one-line thesis distinguishing the two centres; give two named Gupta contributions (Sanskrit court culture, Puranic/temple beginnings) and two named Chola contributions (Brihadisvara-class Dravida temples, Nataraja-class bronzes); close by contrasting texture rather than ranking the two periods.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional Gupta-side example (such as Gupta coinage or the Ajanta-period art overlap) to balance the answer's current Chola-heavy evidence list.

PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2024 (exact wording verified locally)

Question: "Though the great Cholas are no more yet their name is still remembered with great pride because of their highest achievements in the domain of art and architecture." Comment. (Answer in 250 words) 15

Model answer:

The statement is broadly valid because Chola art and architecture transformed political memory into enduring stone and bronze.

The strongest evidence lies in temple architecture. Rajaraja I's Brihadisvara at Thanjavur, Rajendra I's Brihadisvara at Gangaikondacholapuram and Rajaraja II's Airavatesvara at Darasuram together mark the maturity, variation and continuity of Chola monumentality. They combine scale, planning, sculptural detail and durable sacred use; UNESCO's "Great Living Chola Temples" label captures their continued significance.

The second major achievement lies in bronze casting. Chola bronzes, especially Nataraja, represent extraordinary mastery of the lost-wax method. These were not museum pieces but ritual-processional icons embedded in temple life.

Third, art and architecture reflected wider institutions. Great temples were also archives, employers and redistributive centres. Thus Chola art was sustained by agrarian surplus, royal patronage and corporate local society.

Yet pride should not become myth. Chola achievement was not merely aesthetic; it was historical, institutional and regional. Nor should it erase earlier Pallava contributions or later developments.

Conclusion: The Cholas are remembered proudly because their artistic legacy united sacred function, technical excellence and imperial public culture.

Why this earns marks: It converts a quote-based prompt into evidence-backed argument with monument names, bronze example, institutional context and measured qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** on a quoted eulogy of Chola art and architecture requires testing the quote against evidence, not simply agreeing with it.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State agreement with the quote's core claim, then support it with the three named UNESCO temples and Nataraja-class bronzes, add the institutional (archive/labour) dimension, and close by rejecting a purely aesthetic reading.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional dated marker (such as Rajaraja I's 1010 completion of Brihadisvara) to anchor the "pride" claim in a specific, checkable year rather than general praise.

PYQ 04 - UPSC Prelims 2025 GS-I Set A (exact wording and official key verified locally)

Question: Who among the following led a successful military campaign against the kingdom of Srivijaya, the powerful maritime State, which ruled the Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, Java and the neighbouring islands?

A. Amoghavarsha (Rashtrakuta) B. Prataparudra (Kakatiya) C. Rajendra I (Chola) D. Vishnuvardhana (Hoysala)

Answer: C. Explanation: Rajendra I's 1025 expedition against Srivijaya-linked centres is the classic Chola maritime-power event. It shows a successful coercive strike, but not a durable overseas territorial empire.

Why this earns marks: It combines ruler identification with the required caution on the nature of Chola sea power.

Demand decoding: This is a single-fact ruler-identification MCQ: the stem names Srivijaya's Malay-Peninsula/Sumatra/Java reach, and the distractors (Amoghavarsha, Prataparudra, Vishnuvardhana) are plausible early-medieval rulers who never campaigned there.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Eliminate each distractor by dynasty and theatre of operation (Rashtrakuta Deccan, Kakatiya Telangana, Hoysala Karnataka all lack a Srivijaya campaign), then confirm Rajendra I through the 1025 Kadaram-linked expedition.

How to improve this answer: State explicitly why Rajendra I is correct and not merely the "expected" Chola answer: the 1025 expedition is the only one of the four rulers' careers with a documented Srivijaya-linked maritime campaign.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks - Answer in 150 words

Question: "The Kaveri delta, not the open sea, was the real engine of Chola power." Discuss.

Model answer:

The statement is substantially correct. The Cholas became a major early-medieval power because the Kaveri delta generated the surplus that sustained war, temples and administration.

First, delta ecology enabled wet-rice intensification through channels, tanks and branch-river systems. This produced dense settlements, grain assignments and dependable taxation.

Second, the political core of Thanjavur and later Gangaikondacholapuram stood inside this productive zone. Great temples such as Brihadisvara were possible because endowments could be tied to named villages and fields.

Third, maritime activity itself depended on this inland base. Ports, guilds and naval expeditions required food, labour, craft production and fiscal backing.

However, the sea still mattered. Rajendra I's Srivijaya raid and the Sri Lankan campaigns show that the Cholas could project force outward.

Verdict: Chola maritime reach was real, but it rested on the agrarian depth of the Kaveri delta.

Why this earns marks: It states the claim, provides mechanism, concedes the role of the sea and ends with a balanced verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** a quoted claim that privileges the Kaveri delta over the sea requires taking a position, not just listing facts about both.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State qualified agreement, give two named delta-mechanism facts (branch-river/canal irrigation, Thanjavur's and Gangaikondacholapuram's location on the delta edge), concede the sea's role via Rajendra I's Srivijaya raid, and close with a one-line verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific revenue terms (puravu, kadamai) as named evidence that the delta's surplus was administratively captured, not just ecologically present.

Mains 02 - 10 marks - Answer in 150 words

Question: How far does Uttaramerur justify the claim that the Cholas practised local self-government?

Model answer:

Uttaramerur strongly supports the claim that the Cholas recognised structured local self-management, but only with major qualifications.

In support, the inscriptions describe a clear committee system, public lot-drawing through kudavolai, age rules, qualifications, disqualifications and accountability for office-holders. This shows procedural sophistication.

However, Uttaramerur was a Brahmadeya settlement. Eligibility depended on land, house site, scriptural competence and moral standing. Those who failed to render accounts, their close relatives and other excluded groups could not participate.

Therefore, the inscription does not prove universal village democracy. It reveals elite participatory governance within a socially restricted corporate body.

Conclusion: Uttaramerur is excellent evidence of local self-government in a limited, stratified institutional sense - not of modern democratic equality.

Why this earns marks: It gives both the positive and the qualifying half of the answer, which is where most candidates lose marks.

Demand decoding: The directive **how far** requires a two-sided answer: how much Uttaramerur supports local self-government, and where that support runs out.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Give the supporting procedural facts (kudavolai, committee names, age rules) first, then the restrictive facts (Brahmadeya eligibility, land/scriptural qualifications, disqualifications), and close by naming the precise claim it proves versus the claim it does not prove.

How to improve this answer: Name the specific committees (Samvatsara, Eri, Thotta, Pon Variyam) rather than referring only to "a committee system", since naming them is what separates a strong answer from a generic one.

Mains 03 - 15 marks - Answer in 250 words

Question: Temples were central to Chola state formation. Examine.

Model answer:

Temples were central to Chola state formation, though not in an all-controlling sense.

At the ideological level, temples transformed royal conquest into visible sacred legitimacy. Rajaraja I's Brihadisvara, also called Rajarajeshvara, monumentalised imperial authority. Tripurantaka and other Shaiva imagery connected kingship with victory and cosmic order.

At the agrarian level, temples received land endowments, grain assignments and tax-linked support from villages. This tied local surplus to royal and elite religious projects.

At the administrative level, inscriptions on temple walls recorded gifts, offices, salaries, committee decisions and service obligations. Temples functioned as public archives.

At the social-economic level, great temples employed priests, dancers, guards, accountants, artisans and other service groups. Festivals redistributed resources and integrated town and countryside.

However, it would be wrong to say temples controlled the whole economy. Merchant guilds, nagarams, nattar and royal officers retained distinct roles, and not all production or exchange moved through temples.

Verdict: Chola temples were central because they linked kingship, agrarian surplus, public record and social labour, but they were one powerful node within a broader state-society network.

Why this earns marks: It organizes the answer by function, names Brihadisvara, and adds the required limitation instead of overclaiming.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires testing the claim across several distinct functions (ideological, agrarian, administrative, social) rather than asserting it once.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Take Brihadisvara/Rajarajeshvara as the named exemplar, run it through ideological, agrarian, administrative and social-economic functions in turn, then add the merchant-guild/nagaram counterweight before the verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the exact term devadana alongside brahmadeya to show that temple land endowment was a distinct, named legal category, not a vague "land grant".

Mains 04 - 15 marks - Answer in 250 words

Question: Assess the role of merchant guilds in the Chola economy.

Model answer:

Merchant guilds were highly important in the Chola economy, but their role must be assessed in relation to agrarian surplus and state structures rather than as a separate commercial universe.

First, guilds such as Ayyavole / Ainnurruvar, Manigramam, Nanadesi and Anjuvannam gave the Chola world transregional commercial reach. Their activities connect inland markets, port towns, craft production and overseas circuits.

Second, they participated in temple endowments, agreements and property transactions. This shows that commerce, religion and public institutions overlapped.

Third, guilds helped connect the Kaveri agrarian core to Bay of Bengal routes. Ports such as Nagapattinam make sense only when inland production, merchant organization and maritime exchange are brought together.

Yet their role must not be exaggerated. Strong guilds do not prove that the Chola economy was driven by trade alone, nor do they show that all maritime activity was directed by the state. Grain assignments, tax extraction, village institutions and temple demand remained fundamental.

Verdict: Merchant guilds were powerful connectors and multipliers within the Chola economy, but they rested on - and did not replace - the agrarian core.

Why this earns marks: It avoids the false choice between "agrarian economy" and "commercial economy" and gives named guilds as evidence.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires weighing the guilds' importance against the agrarian core, not simply describing what guilds did.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Name the guilds (Ayyavole/Ainnurruvar, Manigramam, Nanadesi, Anjuvannam), connect them to Nagapattinam and the Kaveri hinterland, then state the explicit limit that guild strength does not equal a trade-driven economy before the verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one line on guild-temple interaction (donations, property transactions) to show guilds operated inside, not outside, the existing agrarian-religious institutional order.

Mains 05 - 20 marks - Answer in 250 words

Question: Discuss the nature of Chola maritime power with special reference to Sri Lanka and the 1025 expedition against Srivijaya.

Model answer:

Chola maritime power was real, strategically significant and historically unusual in scale for early-medieval India, but it should not be described in modern imperial-naval terms.

Sri Lanka provides the clearest evidence of sustained maritime campaigning. Rajaraja I attacked the island, destroyed Anuradhapura and annexed Rajarata in the north. Rajendra I continued intervention. This shows that Chola rulers could mobilize shipping, provisioning and military coordination across the sea. Yet southern Sri Lanka remained less securely controlled, and Vijayabahu I eventually expelled the Cholas by 1070.

The 1025 expedition against Srivijaya demonstrates another dimension. Rajendra I's forces struck Srivijaya-linked ports such as Kadaram. The likely motives were prestige, strategic control over trade routes and commercial competition. This was a coercive maritime projection into the Bay of Bengal world.

However, both episodes must be qualified. Sri Lanka was not uniformly controlled; Srivijaya was raided, not permanently colonised. Evidence on ships and formal naval institutions remains limited compared to the rich inscriptional celebration of victory.

Conclusion: Chola maritime power combined transport capacity, coastal-military coordination, strategic commerce and selective coercion. It was stronger than a mere trading presence, but far short of a modern overseas empire.

Why this earns marks: It divides the answer into Sri Lanka, Srivijaya, limitation and verdict - the most scorer-friendly structure.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** with "special reference to" two named cases requires structuring the answer explicitly around Sri Lanka and the 1025 expedition, not maritime power in general.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Treat Sri Lanka and the 1025 Srivijaya expedition as two separate evidence blocks (each with its own named ruler, event and limitation), then close with a single integrating verdict distinguishing strategic-commercial reach from a modern overseas empire.

How to improve this answer: Add Kadaram by name as the specific 1025 target, since naming the target is what distinguishes an evidence-led answer from a general claim about "raiding Southeast Asia".

Mains 06 - 20 marks - Answer in 250 words

Question: Critically examine the major historiographical debates on the Chola state.

Model answer:

The Chola state has generated one of the richest historiographical debates in Indian history because the evidence supports both strong kingship and strong local corporate power.

K. A. Nilakanta Sastri's classic view highlights imperial expansion, ambitious kings, impressive administration, temple-building and maritime achievements. This view captures the scale of Chola power and remains useful for narrative structure.

Burton Stein's segmentary-state model shifted attention to ritual sovereignty, peasant society and the autonomy of locality institutions such as nadu and sabha. His intervention was valuable because it warned historians against reading the Cholas as a modern bureaucratic state.

Inscription-led scholars such as Noboru Karashima and Y. Subbarayalu complicated both views. Their close studies of revenue terms, offices, local divisions, surveys and temporal change show that the Chola polity could centralize in some respects while still depending heavily on local corporate mediation.

A critical synthesis is therefore necessary. Pure centralisation ignores locality; pure segmentary interpretation underplays surveys, campaigns, officials and direct royal intervention.

Verdict: The Chola state is best understood as a negotiated imperial formation - coercive and expansive at the top, but articulated through locally embedded institutions below.

Why this earns marks: It names the major historians, states what each contributes, and ends with an evidence-linked synthetic verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires naming and evaluating specific historians' positions, not summarising "debate exists".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Name Sastri's imperial-centralist reading, Stein's segmentary-state correction, and Karashima/Subbarayalu's inscription-led synthesis in sequence, then state explicitly what each view over-claims before the verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one named inscriptional example (such as Rajaraja I's land survey) to show how Karashima/Subbarayalu's inscription-led method actually operates, rather than naming them without evidence.